COM2020 Team Project

Lecture 4: Presentation skills & writing effective reports

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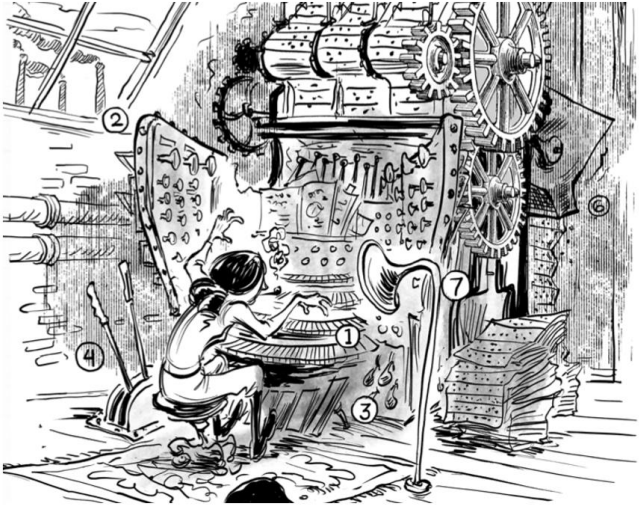
Module Vision



COM2020

Team Project

Teams apply technical skills in software development and data analysis while managing project planning, teamwork, and communication.

Today: What you need for the project presentation + project report

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Part A: Presentation Skills

- Audience + purpose
- Structure and storytelling
- Slides, demo and timing
- Delivery and Q&A

Part B: Writing Effective Reports

- Report structure (software + data)
- Evidence, evaluation, visuals
- Clarity, referencing, integrity
- Accessibility, ethics and responsible computing

Presentation skills for software & data projects

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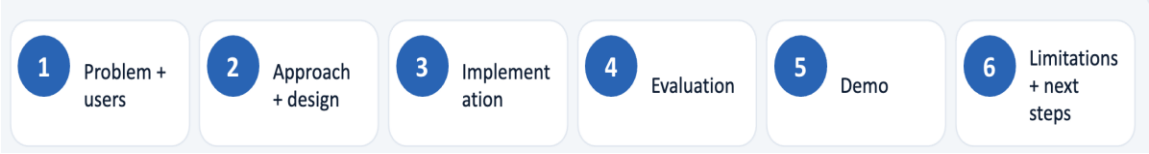
Your message

- What problem did you solve?
- What did you build (and why these choices)?
- How well does it work (evidence)?
- What would you do next (realistic roadmap)?

Your credibility

- Clear scope + assumptions
- Reproducible demo / results
- Honest limitations
- Team contribution is visible

Presentation structure



- One idea per slide; one minute per slide is a good rule of thumb.
- Always define acronyms and metrics the first time you use them.
- Make it obvious what each team member contributed.

Tips & Tricks for Project Presentations

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Project Presentations have to present a coherent and sound story behind a project including:

- A compelling introduction. Briefly sum up what you're going to talk about and why it is relevant.
- Offer a body of evidence. What did you build (and why these choices)? How well does it work (evidence)?
- Sum up with key takeaways at the end. The conclusion is where you loop back to your original statement and give the audience some take-home message.
- What would you do next (realistic roadmap)?

Tips & Tricks for Project Presentations

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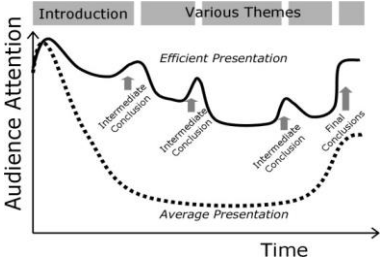
How you **start** and **finish** your presentation will make all the difference.

Audiences usually make up their minds about someone in **the first 7 seconds**, so make those first moments count.



Tips & Tricks for Project Presentations

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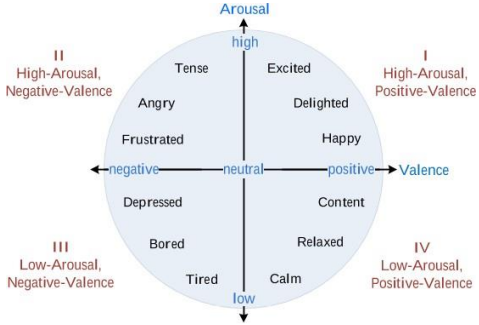

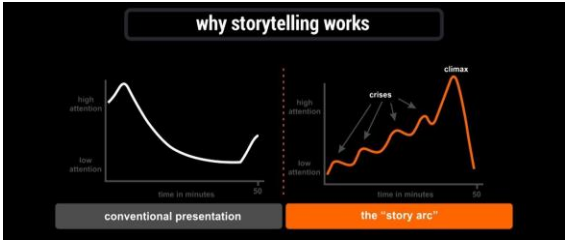

Emotions can greatly help you in keeping the attention of the audience.

In the circumplex model of emotions (Posner et al. 2005), you can boost people's attention by:

- Eliciting alertness or tension – e.g. Hiring people is becoming too costly!
- Shifting the arousal to more pleasant emotions – e.g. we can solve this with AI (maybe)!

Tips & Tricks for Project Presentations

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Cognitive neuroscience can also facilitate your delivery.

Before a presentation, try to perform a light physical activity – in 2 minutes the brain will stimulate adrenaline production (Glisezinski et al. 2009).

Adrenaline facilitates the regulation of alertness and similar high-arousal emotions ->
You will speak more fluently and be more aware of the presentation.

Speak loud and clear.
Do not rush. Take your time.
Practice! Presentations should be prepared and practiced like a stage-play.

Tips & Tricks for Slides

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Do

- Use big fonts (≥24pt) and plenty of whitespace
- Prefer diagrams: architecture, data flow, pipeline
- Show results visually (tables, charts, confusion matrix)
- Label axes/units and explain what “good” looks like

Avoid

- Walls of text / copying from the report
- Tiny screenshots of code
- Unexplained metrics (e.g., “F1=0.71” with no context)
- Over-styling: gradients, excessive animations

Tips & Tricks for Demos

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Demo checklist

- Start with a single sentence: “In the next 90 seconds we’ll show …”
- Use known inputs (or seeded data) to avoid surprises
- Have a backup plan: screenshots/video + dataset
- Know where your logs are and what success looks like
- If something breaks: narrate calmly → switch to backup → explain why

Tips & Tricks for Delivery & Q&A

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Delivery habits

- Lead with the key point, then explain
- Speak in short sentences; pause between sections
- Point to the slide only when needed
- Time yourself and cut ruthlessly

Q&A technique

- Repeat the question in your own words
- Answer first, then justify
- If you do not know: say what you would test next
- Use evidence: metrics, logs, design trade-offs

How to Write An Effective Project Report

Writing effective reports

A report is the “audit trail” of your project

Your report should allow a reader to:

- Understand the problem and the context (who, why, constraints)
- See a justified approach (requirements → design → implementation)
- Verify quality with evidence (tests, evaluation, results)
- Reproduce your work (setup, data, configuration, instructions)
- Judge professionalism (clarity, structure, references, integrity)

Structure of your Project Report

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Give a structure to your document

Introduction

- What is the problem?
- What are the aims and objectives?
- What you built?

Design & Related work

- Architecture, dataflow rationale
- Indicate if similar approaches tackling same challenge
- How is your work advance science?

Implementation/Methods & Materials

- Key components, tools
- What data for analysis?
- What methods for analysis?

Evaluation

- Test, metrics, results
- What evaluation approach?
- Compare results/output with baseline

Management

- How group work together?
- Who does what?

Risks & Discussion

- Pros & cons of strategy
- How the project could fail?
- How team can prevent failures?

Appendices to your Project Report

- Setup/run instructions (reproducibility)
- API docs / endpoints / schema
- Test plan and coverage summary
- Data dictionary + preprocessing steps
- Team contributions (transparent roles)

Evidence and evaluation

Show what you tested and why the results matter

Engineering evidence

- Unit + integration tests (what is covered)
- Performance: response time, throughput, memory
- Reliability: error handling, edge cases
- Security basics: auth, input validation

Data/analytics evidence

- Data quality checks (missingness, outliers)
- Baselines (simple method for comparison)
- Metrics with interpretation (not just numbers)
- Limitations: bias, leakage, generalisation

Rule: every metric must answer a question the project cares about.

Style, clarity and referencing

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Clarity rules

- Lead with the point; details follow
- Define terms and abbreviations once
- Use figures/tables with captions that “tell the story”
- Prefer short paragraphs and informative headings

Academic integrity

- Cite sources for datasets, libraries, and ideas
- Label any AI-assisted writing/code appropriately (AI-minimal instruction)
- Do not include secrets/keys in the submission
- Keep a traceable contribution record

Accessibility, Ethics &Responsible Computing

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You are expected to demonstrate:

- Accessibility awareness (basic keyboard navigation, readable layout, mobile-friendly where relevant)
- Security basics (no secrets in repo/ZIP, safe demo accounts, sensible data handling)
- Ethical and legal thinking (privacy, harm risk, licensing/IP, fairness where relevant)
- Societal and environmental impact reflection appropriate to your project

Individual Reflection

Each student must submit an individual reflection on ELE (not in the group repository).

Suggested length: 800–1,000 words.

This reflection is used to evidence individual learning and contribution and may be used to resolve contribution disputes.

- Your role and contributions: describe what you owned (features, testing, documentation, deployment). Reference concrete evidence (links, issue IDs, commits).

Individual Reflection cont.

- What you learned: at least three specific technical or professional learning points linked to module outcomes (e.g., requirements negotiation, risk management, testing, deployment).
- Challenges and how you addressed them: one technical challenge and one teamwork/process challenge; what changed as a result.
- Responsible computing: what ethical/legal risk you personally focused on (privacy, accessibility, safety) and how you mitigated it.

References

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